



Fast Fashion: Key Definition & Statistics

- **Definition:**
Fast fashion refers to the rapid production and sale of trendy, inexpensive clothing. Brands like H&M and Shein compress design and manufacturing cycles to release new collections weekly or even daily.
 - **Key Stats:**
 - Global apparel industry reached **\$1.7 trillion in 2023**.
 - **Clothing production doubled** from 2000 to 2014.
 - Cheapest garments are **discarded after only ~7 wears**.
 - **For every 5 new garments made, 3 end up in landfill or incinerated.**
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Water Use & Pollution

- **Water Usage:**
 - **700 gallons** of water needed to produce **one cotton shirt**.
 - **2,000 gallons** for a **pair of jeans**.
 - **Dyeing Pollution:**
 - Textile dyeing is the **#2 industrial water polluter** globally.
 - Untreated chemicals often dumped into water bodies.
 - **Microplastic Pollution:**
 - Washing synthetic garments releases **500,000 tons of microfibers annually** – equivalent to **50 billion plastic bottles** – into oceans.
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Carbon Footprint & Waste

- **Carbon Emissions:**
 - Fashion industry contributes **~10% of global CO₂ emissions** – more than **all international flights and shipping combined**.
 - Projected to **increase by 60% by 2030** if current trends continue.
 - **Textile Waste:**
 - **85% of textiles end up in landfills or are incinerated** yearly.
 - Consumers lose **\$460 billion annually** by discarding lightly used clothing.
 - Only **~8% of textile fibers are recycled**; the rest pollutes land and water.
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Social Impact & Labor

- **Workforce Stats:**

- Around **75 million garment workers** globally.
 - In India, **45 million** people (mostly women) work in textiles and apparel.
 - **Wages & Conditions:**
 - **Less than 2%** of garment workers earn a **living wage**.
 - Common issues include **unsafe conditions, long hours, and labor abuse**.
 - **Rana Plaza collapse** highlighted deadly factory risks.
 - **Child Labor Cases:**
 - In 2023, **Shein** reported **two cases of child labor** and **unpaid wage violations** in its supply chain.
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Circular Economy & Initiatives

- **Brand Initiatives:**
 - **Patagonia Worn Wear** resale program earned **\$5 million in 2023**.
 - **H&M's take-back program** collected over **172,000 tonnes** of old clothing.
 - **"Jeans Redesign" project** produced **1.5+ million pairs of jeans** that are easier to recycle.
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India-Specific Circular Economy Stats

- **Textile Waste Generation:**
 - India generates **~7.7 million tonnes of textile waste annually** (≈8.5% of global total).
 - **Recycling & Reuse:**
 - **59% of textile waste is reused or recycled** domestically.
 - Formalizing textile sorting could **reclaim 1.38 million tonnes/year**.
 - **Economic Potential:**
 - Potential revenue from textile recycling: **INR ₹388–1,348 crore annually**.
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Material & Technology Innovations

- **Mycelium Leather:**
 - Made from **fungus mycelium** and **agricultural waste**.
 - Requires **much less water and energy** than animal leather.
 - Already used by high-end brands like **Hermès** (via MycoWorks).
- **Recycled & Plant-Based Fibers:**
 - **Recycled polyester and nylon** from plastic bottles/old garments.
 - **Natural fiber alternatives:**

- **Piñatex** (pineapple leaves)
 - **Apple-derived leather**
 - **Hemp, bamboo, and TENCEL**
 - These are **biodegradable and less resource-intensive**, though still a small share globally.
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Youth Activism & Call-to-Action

- **Campaigns:**
 - **#WhoMadeMyClothes** and **#WhatsInMyClothes** – transparency and accountability campaigns run by **Fashion Revolution**.
 - Fashion Revolution India hosts **workshops and events** promoting ethical production.
 - **Student-Led Action:**
 - **Campus clothing swaps** and **thrift drives** (e.g. Earth Day’s “Swap for the Earth” toolkit) encourage reuse.
 - Students launch **thrift shops, upcycling projects**, and promote **natural dyes and recycled textiles** in their designs.
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